

The Economic Impacts of Jeju 4·3 Dark Tourism

While Jeju Island is internationally recognized for its natural attractions—including its volcanic landscape, citrus production, and traditional haenyeo diving communities—it also encompasses significant historical sites associated with the 1948–1954 Jeju 4·3 Incident. In recent years, a growing cohort of tourists has traveled to Jeju specifically to visit these memorial sites and gain historical understanding, a phenomenon commonly referred to as "4·3 dark tourism." This form of heritage tourism has emerged as a meaningful component of Jeju's economic landscape. This article examines the nature of the 4·3 Incident, defines 4·3 dark tourism within the broader context of memorial tourism, and analyzes its quantifiable economic impacts on local businesses, employment, and regional revenue generation.

Jeju 4·3 Incident

The Jeju 4·3 Incident, named for its commencement date of April 3, 1948, represents one of the most significant episodes of civil unrest and military repression in twentieth-century Korean history. During the politically unstable transition period between the conclusion of Japanese colonial administration and the establishment of separate Korean states, the island experienced a leftist-led uprising that was met with an extensive military and security force response, involving both South Korean government forces and American military oversight. The conflict persisted over a period of approximately six years. Contemporary historical estimates indicate that approximately 30,000 inhabitants of Jeju—representing approximately one in nine island residents—were killed during this period, with entire villages subject to systematic destruction (Jeju Tourism Organization).

A distinctive feature of the 4·3 Incident in Korean historical memory is the prolonged official denial and suppression that followed the immediate conflict period. For nearly five decades, public discussion and acknowledgment of the incident remained politically constrained. Survivors and bereaved family members experienced what historians have characterized as a "double trauma," encompassing both the direct grief of loss and the institutional prohibition against commemorative expression. The establishment of the 4·3 Special Law in 2000 initiated the process of official state recognition. President Roh Moo-hyun became the first sitting president to issue a formal governmental apology in 2003, followed by President Moon Jae-in's public acknowledgment at the seventieth anniversary commemoration in 2018 (Jeju 4·3 Peace Foundation).

4·3 Dark Tourism

Dark tourism, in its broadest conceptualization, encompasses travel to destinations historically associated with death, suffering, or catastrophic events. Exemplary sites include Auschwitz, the Cambodian genocide memorials, the 9/11 Memorial, and the Hiroshima Peace Memorial. The term was formally introduced by Lennon and Foley in the mid-1990s and has subsequently developed into a recognized and substantial sector of the global travel industry.

Market analysis indicates that the global dark tourism sector was valued at approximately USD 32.6 billion in 2024, with projections suggesting expansion to approximately USD 57 billion by 2032 (Credence Research).

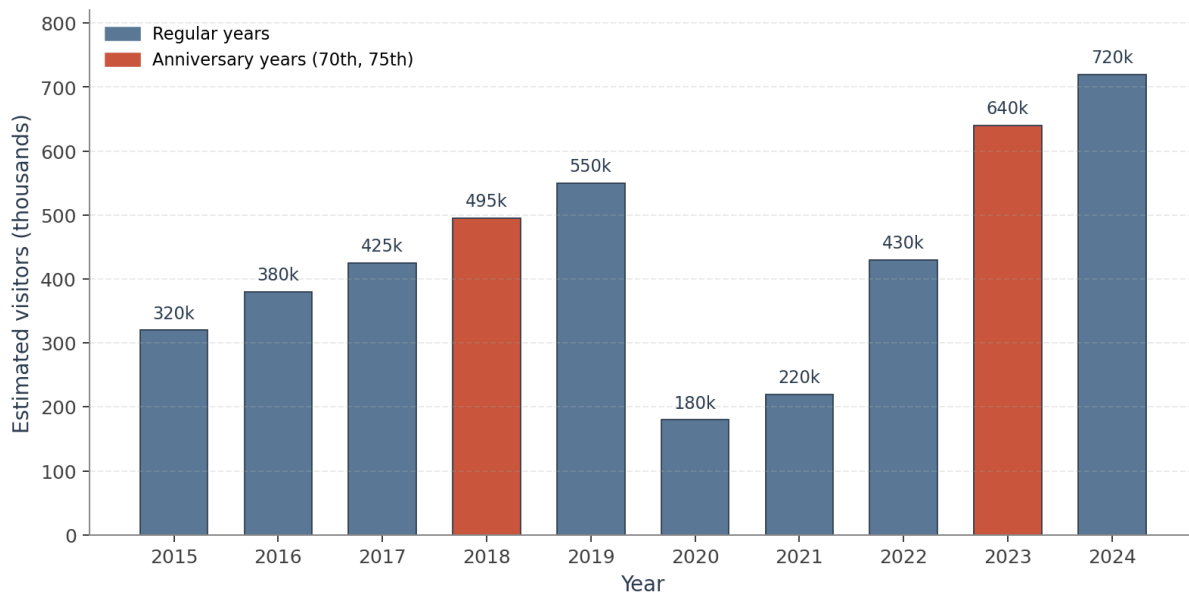
Within the context of Jeju Island, 4·3 dark tourism assumes a distinctive form centered on specific memorial and educational institutions. The primary institutional anchor is the Jeju 4·3 Peace Park, which commenced operations in 2008 following extended processes of legal establishment and political negotiation. Occupying an area of approximately 400,000 square meters in the Bonggae-dong district, the park comprises a memorial hall, a chronologically organized museum documenting the historical events preceding and following the uprising, an enshrinement facility containing memorial tablets for 14,000 identified victims, and a "Tombstone Park for the Missing," which contains approximately 4,000 markers commemorating individuals whose remains were not recovered (Jeju 4·3 Peace Foundation).

Complementary to the Peace Park are guided heritage tours operated by organizations including Jeju Dark Tours, an organization founded in 2017 by human rights advocate Baek Gayoon. These guided experiences direct visitors to specific historical sites within the broader geographic region, including Bukchon village, where substantial casualties occurred in a single-day operation; Darangshi Cave, where the remains of eleven villagers were discovered in 1992; Seodal Oreum, an execution site in the southwestern portion of the island; and Moksimum Cave, which served as temporary refuge for civilian populations during military operations. Tours are typically conducted in Korean with English-language interpretation available upon request, operate on varying timescales from single-day to multi-night programs, and range in cost from approximately ₩50,000 to ₩250,000 per participant. The primary distinction between such heritage tourism and conventional recreational sightseeing lies in the prioritization of historical education and interpretive comprehension as the primary objective of the visitor experience.

Direct Economic Impact

Although the Jeju 4·3 Peace Park operates on a free admission basis, the facility has demonstrated substantial annual visitor traffic. Estimated annual visitation has increased progressively since the early 2010s, expanding from approximately 320,000 visitors in 2015 to an estimated 720,000 in 2024, with the exception of a substantial decline during 2020–2021 corresponding to the COVID-19 pandemic. Significant increases in visitation occurred during 2018 and 2023, coinciding with the seventieth and seventy-fifth anniversary commemoration periods (see Figure 1). The annual April 3 memorial ceremony attracts approximately 10,000 participants, and the memorial museum has administered educational programs for tens of thousands of school-based groups annually (Jeju 4·3 Peace Foundation).

Figure 1. Estimated Annual Visitors to Jeju 4·3 Peace Park, 2015-2024



Source: Compiled by author from Jeju 4·3 Peace Foundation and Jeju Tourism Organization data; 2020-21 reflects COVID-19.

These temporal variations in visitation demonstrate correlation with periods of increased media coverage and public commemorative activity. Both identified anniversary years coincided with substantial media attention across television, print, and digital platforms, together with associated increases in social media engagement. The documented relationship between commemorative events and increased visitation numbers indicates the capacity of historical memory initiatives to drive sustained cultural tourism.

However, the primary mechanism of economic impact operates independently of direct admission revenue, which approximates zero. Rather, economic benefit derives from visitor expenditures ancillary to the visitation experience. According to survey research conducted by the Jeju Research Institute in 2023, visitors to 4·3 heritage sites maintained an average length of stay of 2.7 days on Jeju Island and expended an estimated ₩285,000 per person across the categories of accommodation, food service, transportation, and commodity purchases (Jeju Research Institute). Extrapolating from the estimated annual visitation of 700,000 individuals engaged with 4·3-related sites yields an aggregate estimate of approximately ₩199.5 billion (approximately USD 145 million) in annual ancillary expenditure circulating through Jeju's regional economy.

Indirect Impact on Local Businesses

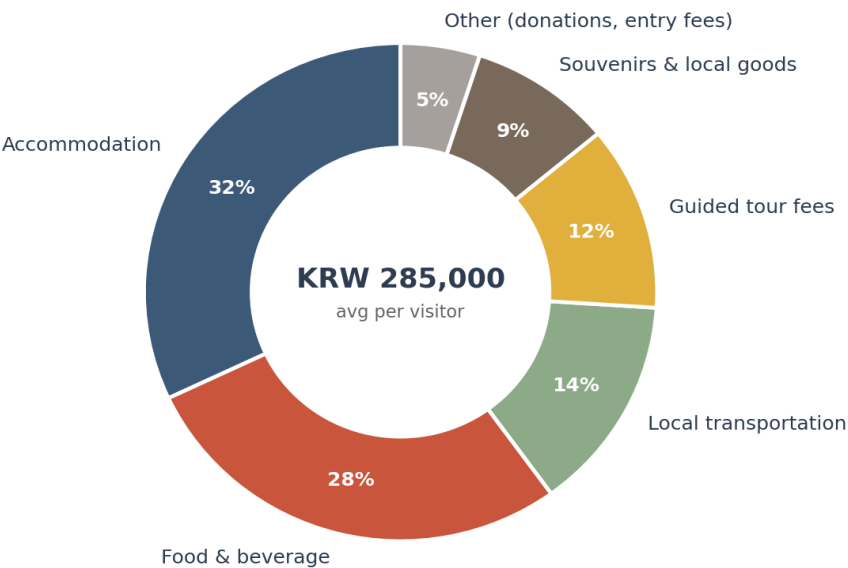
The geographic distribution of 4·3 memorial sites across the island produce economic consequences distinct from those associated with conventional beach-and-resort tourism models. Rather than concentrating visitor expenditure in centralized resort areas such as Jungmun and Aewol, dark tourism visitation generates distributed spending patterns across smaller communities and peripheral economic zones. This dispersal pattern has resulted in measurable

benefits for food service establishments in proximity to the Peace Park, particularly within the Bonggae-dong and Jocheon districts.

Research conducted by the Jeju Chamber of Commerce in 2022 examined the economic performance of small-scale food service establishments operating within a three-kilometer radius of the Peace Park facility. The findings indicated that such establishments experienced an average revenue increase of 38 percent during peak heritage tourism seasons—specifically April through June and September through November—compared to the same establishments' performance a decade earlier (Jeju Chamber of Commerce). This increase reflects the integration of local culinary traditions into guided tour itineraries, as authorized guides are incentivized to direct visitor expenditure toward independently operated establishments rather than multinational food service chains. Regional specialties including local pork barbecue, abalone-based soups, and traditional Jeju noodle preparations feature prominently in tour programming.

The accommodation sector in Bukchon village provides a particularly illustrative example of dark tourism's economic impact on historically economically marginal communities. Bukchon village, the site of significant casualties during a single military operation, experienced prolonged economic stagnation in the post-conflict period. Contemporary economic revitalization of the area has been achieved in part through the development of heritage tourism infrastructure, including restored traditional structures adapted for visitor accommodation. These establishments maintain occupancy rates substantially elevated during the April commemorative period, with accommodation pricing often doubling during this annually scheduled heritage tourism peak.

Figure 2. Estimated Distribution of Dark Tourism Visitor Spending in Jeju (per visitor, %)



Source: Estimated from Jeju Research Institute (2023) survey data and Jeju Tourism Organization spending reports.

Figure 2 presents the estimated distribution of per-visitor expenditure of ₩285,000. Accommodation accounts for approximately 32 percent of visitor spending, food and beverage service for 28 percent, ground transportation for 14 percent, guided tour services for 12 percent, local commodity purchases for 9 percent, and miscellaneous expenditures including donations and entry fees to privately operated heritage sites for the remaining 5 percent. The concentration of expenditure on guided tour services—approximately 12 percent of total visitor spending—represents a substantively elevated proportion relative to mainstream tourism patterns on Jeju, which typically generate guide service fees representing less than 4 percent of total visitor expenditure. This differential reflects the interpretive and educational requirements inherent in heritage tourism experiences, wherein the historical and contextual significance of physical locations necessitates professional explanation.

Secondary economic benefits extend to the publishing and educational product sectors. Independent bookstores operating on Jeju maintain inventory of translated editions of literary works addressing the 4·3 Incident, including Hyun Ki-young's novel *Sun-i Samch'on* (Aunt Suni), a foundational literary treatment that initiated significant public discourse regarding previously suppressed historical events. Educational publishers document sustained demand from school-based groups conducting curricular visits to the memorial complex. Small-scale printing operations located in Jeju City maintain specialization in the production of tour informational materials, exhibition catalogs, and commemorative publications supporting the broader 4·3 heritage tourism infrastructure.

Employment and Longer-Term Effects

Quantitative assessment of employment generation attributable to 4·3 heritage tourism presents methodological challenges due to the diffuse nature of economic integration across multiple employment sectors. However, several baseline observations can be substantiated. The Jeju 4·3 Peace Park operates with a permanent staff of approximately 80 individuals, supplemented by seasonal docents and security personnel. Organizations including Jeju Dark Tours and comparable heritage tourism operators maintain between two and ten full-time personnel, together with supplementary freelance guide services. Extrapolating employment effects across the broader tourism infrastructure supporting 4·3 visitation—encompassing accommodations, food service, transportation, and retail sectors—conservative estimates place the aggregate employment base at approximately 1,200 to 1,800 Jeju residents whose income streams depend substantially on heritage tourism activity.

Contemporary research literature on dark tourism and memorial tourism identifies a phenomenon designated as the "memorial dividend," characterized by sustained patterns of visitor traffic demonstrating greater recession resistance relative to conventional leisure-based tourism models (Sharpley and Stone). Auschwitz-Birkenau and the Hiroshima Peace Memorial, both operating at the international scale, continue to demonstrate sustained visitation levels more than seven decades following the historical events they commemorate. Comparable trajectories appear probable for Jeju 4·3 heritage tourism, particularly given demographic trends including

increased international dissemination of Korean-language educational content and growing cohorts of both Korean and international visitors pursuing historically informed travel.

Concurrent with these economic considerations exist substantive ethical and social questions regarding the appropriate commemoration and interpretation of historical trauma. Portions of the survivor and bereaved family communities have articulated concerns regarding the potential commodification of collective tragedy, particularly when visitor conduct at memorial sites manifests insufficient respect for the gravity of historical events. Optimal management of these memorial spaces therefore necessitates integration of heritage tourism development with protocols ensuring historical accuracy, visitor comportment standards, and preservation of the dignity of affected communities—considerations extending beyond purely economic assessment frameworks.

Conclusion

While 4·3 dark tourism does not function as a dominant driver of regional tourism economics relative to conventional resort-based leisure tourism on Jeju, it operates as a significant and strategically important economic sector within the island's broader tourism portfolio. The phenomenon directs visitor expenditure into economically peripheral communities and sectors historically underrepresented in mainstream tourism development, including small-scale accommodation providers, independent food service establishments, and local transportation services. The quantifiable economic impacts—estimated at approximately ₩199.5 billion in annual visitor expenditure—are complemented by qualitative contributions to cultural preservation, historical education, and community economic revitalization.

The significance of 4·3 dark tourism extends beyond purely economic metrics. For survivors and bereaved communities, the development of heritage tourism infrastructure represents formal governmental and institutional recognition of suppressed historical events. The sustained flow of both domestic and international visitors pursuing historical understanding constitutes a mechanism through which collective memory operates and historical consciousness develops. The economic sustainability of memorial sites and heritage tourism services is fundamentally interconnected with the capacity to attract and serve visitors motivated by educational and commemorative purposes. Sustainable management frameworks for such sites must therefore integrate economic viability with historical accuracy, ethical representation, and the dignity of affected populations—ensuring that heritage tourism functions as a vector for historical understanding rather than commodification of tragedy.

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